RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR

YELLOW SEA



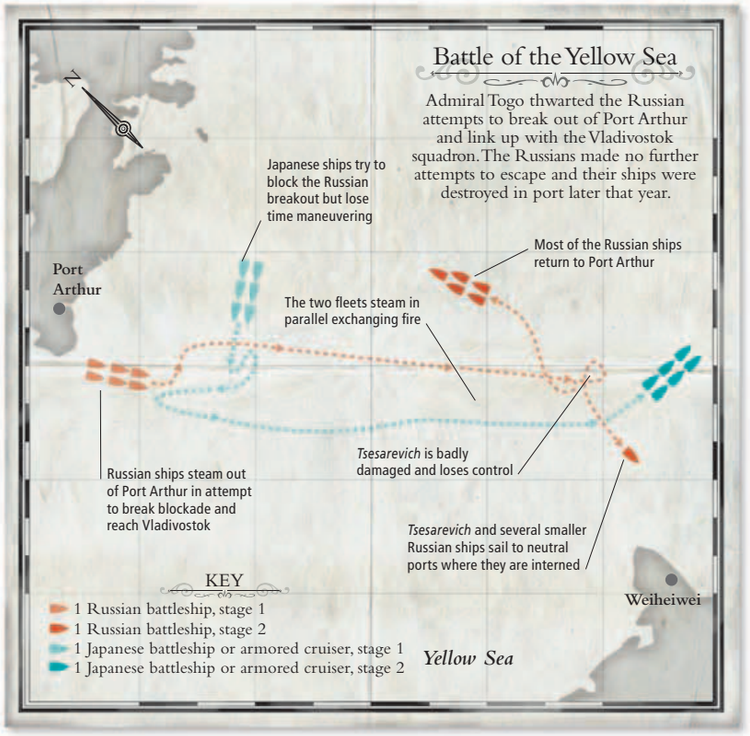
Location Off Shantung Peninsula, China

Date August 10, 1904
Forces Japanese: 4 battleships, 2 armored cruisers, 8 other cruisers, 18 destroyers, 30 torpedo boats; Russians: 6 battleships, 4 cruisers, 8 destroyers
Losses Japanese: none; Russians: 1 battleship, 2 cruisers, 4 destroyers interned in neutral ports

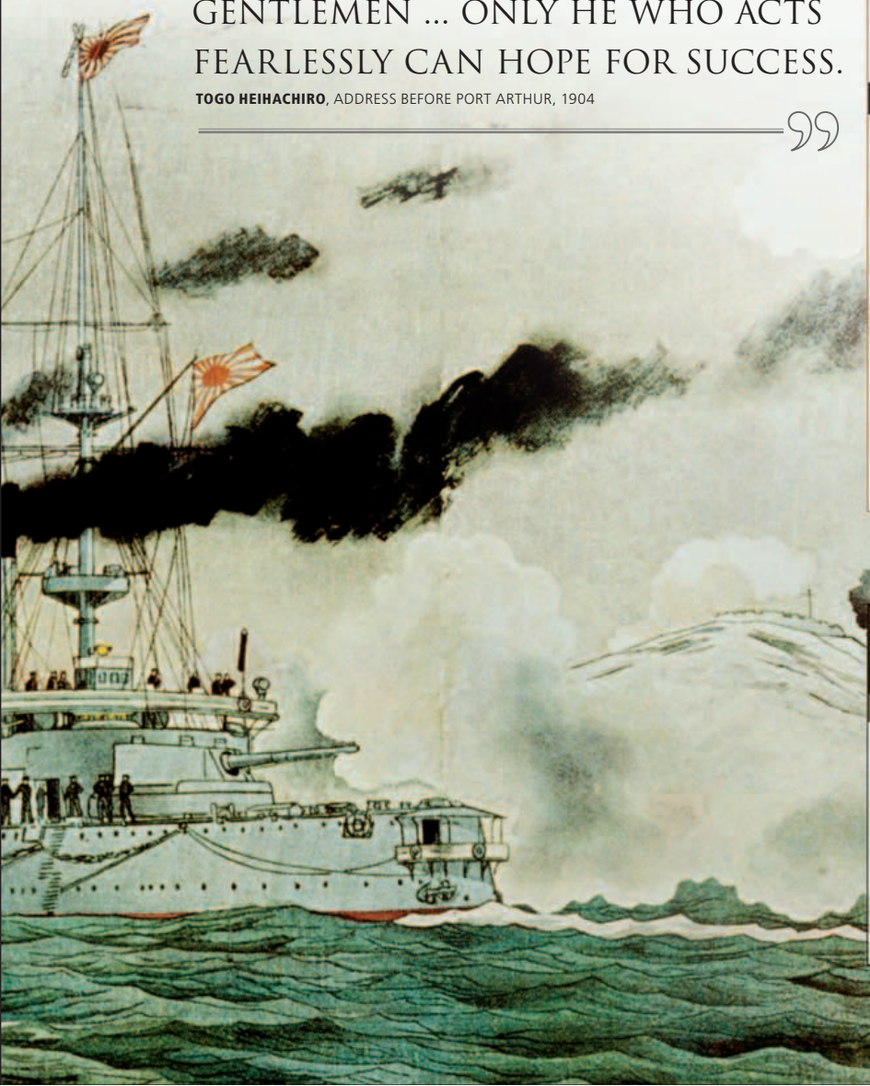
After being blockaded in harbor for six months, on August 10, 1904, the Russian First Pacific Squadron steamed out into the Yellow Sea. Its commander, Rear Admiral Vilgelm Karlovich Vitgeft, was obeying a personal order from Tsar Nicholas II to join the rest of the Russian Pacific fleet in Vladivostok. Vitgeft personally considered the breakout attempt doomed to failure.

Admiral Togo, commanding the Japanese blockade from the battleship *Mikasa*, prepared to engage the Russians as they came out, but surprisingly missed them. Executing maneuvers designed primarily to keep his own flagship in the van, he found himself pursuing the Russians from a good distance behind. Fortunately for Togo the Russian ships were slow and by 5:00 p.m. his four battleships and two armored cruisers were in position to engage the six Russian battleships. Steaming in line ahead on a parallel course, the ships bombarded one another ferociously. Eyewitnesses described the gigantic columns of water thrown up by the shells, the noise of explosions, clouds of foul smoke, and decks streaming with blood. *Mikasa* was hit repeatedly but it was Vitgeft's flagship *Tsesarevich* that suffered worst. The key moment in the battle occurred when two shells struck *Tsesarevich*'s bridge. Vitgeft and all his senior officers were killed. Out of control, the battleship was stuck in a turn to port that many other Russian ships blindly followed, looping pointlessly.

As night fell most of the Russian fleet headed back to Port Arthur. *Tsesarevich* and some other ships sought refuge in neutral ports, where they were interned. The First Pacific Squadron would play no further part in the war.



> THE ATTACK MUST BE DELIVERED WITH THE GREATEST ENERGY POSSIBLE BECAUSE, GENTLEMEN ... ONLY HE WHO ACTS FEARLESSLY CAN HOPE FOR SUCCESS.
>
> **TOGO HEIHACHIRO**, ADDRESS BEFORE PORT ARTHUR, 1904



RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR



THE BATTLE OF PORT ARTHUR

Date	February 8–9, 1904
Location	Liaodong peninsula
Result	Inconclusive

COMBATANTS

JAPAN	RUSSIA

COMMANDERS

Heihachiro Togo	Oscar Stark

FORCES

Ships: Japan: 6 battleships, 5 cruisers, 35 destroyers and torpedo boats	**Ships:** Russia: 7 battleships, 5 cruisers, various smaller vessels

LOSSES

Men: 132 casualties **Ships:** none	**Men:** 150 casualties **Ships:** none

RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR

THE JAPANESE SEA



Location Off Ulsan, Korea

Date August 14, 1904
Forces Japanese: 4 armored cruisers; 2 protected cruisers
Russians: 3 armored cruisers
Losses Japanese: none; Russians: 1 cruiser

Russian rear admiral Karl Jessen was sent out of Vladivostok with armored cruisers *Rossia*, *Gromoboi*, and *Rurik* to meet the First Pacific Squadron coming from Port Arthur. Jessen was unaware of the defeat at the Yellow Sea, but turned for home when the squadron failed to appear. Unfortunately he ran into a stronger force of Japanese cruisers under Vice Admiral Kamimura. *Rurik*, the rearmost Russian ship, came under heavy bombardment. Disabled and with most of her officers dead, the cruiser gallantly maintained defensive fire until scuttled by the few survivors. *Rossia* and *Gromoboi*, at Kamimura's mercy, were inexplicably allowed to escape.

WITNESS TO WAR

LIEUTENANT ANDREI PETROVICH STEER

SINKING OF THE RUSSIAN FLAGSHIP PETROPAVLOVSK OUTSIDE PORT ARTHUR

RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR

In quick succession, ***a series of perfectly deafening explosions****, and the big ship literally broken into several parts,* ***began to go down fast, head foremost****. We saw by degrees the propellers, still revolving, appear out of the water, then her bottom, painted bright green,* ***while positive sheets of flame ran along the upper deck*** *... she finally disappeared in a veritable geyser of steam and columns of water.*